

The Statistical Significance of Statistical Insignificance. A Reproduction Study of ‘The Null Result Penalty’

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Abstract

Chopra et al. (2023) assesses whether scientific studies with null result findings are perceived as less publishable. Using a randomized controlled trial, the authors randomize a series of study vignettes to present statistically significant or statistically insignificant results. They present these vignettes to a sample of economists to judge the publishability and merit of these studies. They confirm that economists view null results as less publishable, as well as less important and having lower quality. We computationally reproduce their results using two statistical softwares – Stata and R. Despite being reproducible, we find a strange distribution of the primary outcome measure in the data which may explain the highly robust findings. To validate this study, we advocate for a replication of this study using a new sample of respondents and a separate set of researchers.

KEYWORDS: Economic Methodology, Communication, Peer Review

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2 Data Availability Statement

We thank the authors of Chopra et al. (2023) for publicly providing the replication data and code for their study. The replication packet for the original study can be found on Zenodo: <https://zenodo.org/records/8168773>. We have produced a replication packet for our analysis using Github and will comply with the Journal of Applied Econometrics standard of publicly uploading this replication packet.

3 Funding Statement

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4 Conflict of Interest Disclosure

The authors declare no conflict of interests replicating this study nor prior relationships with the authors of the study replicated.